



gation of mutually repelling particles, simply fly apart. And yet, we don't. Clearly a different paradigm is at work—a paradigm in which, paradoxically, this very smorgasbord of diversity must play a pivotal role in keeping the country together.

The phrase "Unity in diversity" comes to mind—a concept that Wikipedia, the online encyclopedia, asserts is best exemplified by India. According to this philosophy, the danger of fragmentation for a highly diverse society is so acute that it is forced to develop a heightened sense of tolerance to internal differences to survive. In other words, it is the threat of our country breaking apart that keeps us united.

While there is some truth in this idea, it neither captures the full picture, nor explains the mechanism by which such unity might actually be fostered. Consider that aggregation of 1.2 billion individual particles again, many of them rural and illiterate, all of them subject to intense pressure from their own particular needs and prejudices. Surely the most immediate and compelling motivation that drives them (in fact, that drives anyone, Finns included) is self-interest. Try explaining the Wikipedia entry to a poor farmer (or, for that matter a rich businessman)—tell him how a grand social theory predicts he will rise above his own immediate needs to ensure that the flag of unity is always kept aloft. He will laugh in your face.

And yet, a model of independent entrepreneurship does not apply either. Rugged individualism in the American sense is not the order of the day. People belong to well-defined communities—clan, village, sect, *biradari*—and it is membership in these that turns out to be of primary significance. Rather than 1.2 billion separate particles,

the Indian model can be thought of as organised into a much smaller number of groups. The sense of belonging within each such group is extremely strong—the individual's social sustenance (not to mention very identity) is often entirely dependent on it. As a result, self-interest is no longer always the dominant motivator—rather, it might be subsumed into the interests of the group.

What makes these groups so attractive? What endows them with their strong sense of identity, their stability, their cohesive power? The driving force, I believe, is diversity. The groups derive their strength precisely from the inhomogeneity of the larger society from which they are drawn. While there might be several socioeconomic and evolutionary arguments favouring diversity, it is not necessarily something easy to live with. Alien customs can be surprisingly grating. People yearn to hear their own language. The natural defence against an onslaught of difference is to seek those like oneself. This is exactly what the group offers—a refuge from "The Other." One can seek comfort in a community of individuals with the same customs, the same

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